

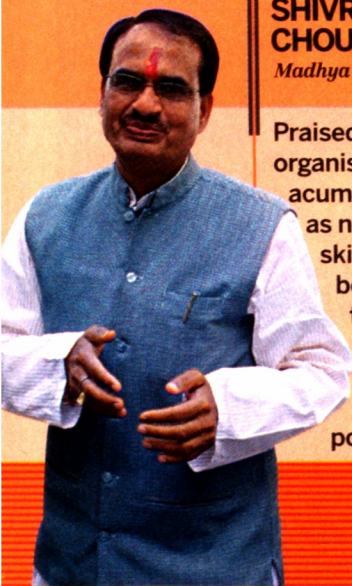
Waiting List

The party is relying heavily on its second-rung leadership

SHIVRAJ SINGH CHOUHAN

Madhya Pradesh chief minister

Praised for his organisational acumen as well as networking skills. Has been asked to chip in with Madhya Pradesh polls.



PANKAJ TIWARI

ARUN JAITLEY

Party General Secretary

The IPL and elections are expected to clash and the master strategist will have to juggle his time effectively since he is not contesting.

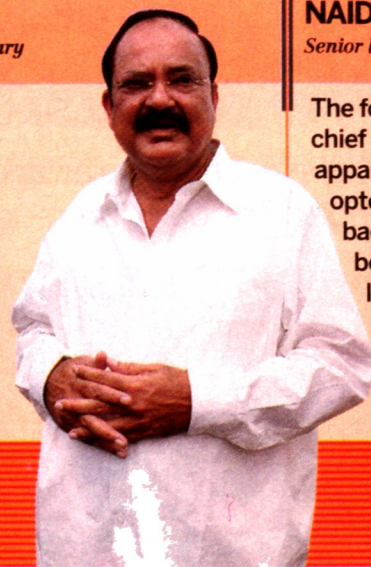


SHEKHAR YADAV

M. VENKAIAH NAIDU

Senior leader

The former party chief and apparatchik has opted to be a backroom boy. Will look after southern states and alliances.



SIPRA DAS

party still can't come to terms with the devastating humiliation of 2004. Four years should have been long enough for it to recover and emerge as the natural alternative. It is in the danger of vacating the Right's space in Indian politics. It is even losing the vigour and vocabulary of a responsible opposition. In the age of "change", the BJP is steeped in old certainties.

In Nagpur, it could not even settle on a viable, saleable agenda. Should it aspire to be the centre-right party as personified by the irreplaceable Atal Bihari Vajpayee? Or should it bring Ram to the vanguard in an election year? There was no consensus, and it was best brought out by the party's prime ministerial candidate L.K. Advani who was not sure of what he wanted to be: the moderate, mellowed *yatri* close to his destination, or the RSS-friendly leader of Hindutva? He was visibly uncomfortable when party President Rajnath Singh passionately raised the issue of Ram Mandir. Surprisingly—or was it predictable?—Advani endorsed it the next day, much to the discomfiture of BJP's already reluctant allies who would rather have the party fighting on a platform of development, good

governance and national security. Advani, on his part, had no option but to stand up for the Mandir for the sake of the party's core constituency and a semblance of unity.

The return of the temple to the battlefield has not gone down well with two main NDA allies: the JD(U) and the BJD. They are anyway having second thoughts about continuing their alliance with the BJP. Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar has been bargaining hard with the BJP for a greater seat share. Even BJD leader and Orissa Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik has expressed unhappiness over the BJP's Hindutva agenda, especially in the wake of anti-Christian violence in his state.

In his desperate bid to keep everybody happy, Advani, in yet another detour, abandoned the Mandir again

and returned to the middle path, promising "genuine secularism" which stands for equal rights for citizens of all religions. And he knows the BJP can't win alone. Advani can't afford to lose allies. Even the so-called "positive agenda" of good governance, development and security, has been relegated to the background.

Hindutva apart, the BJP also found itself at sea in defining its economic agenda. Though Yashwant Sinha put forth a well argued economic resolution, Rajnath in his speech invoked the teachings of Mahatma Gandhi and Pandit Deen Dayal Upadhyaya to take the country out of the economic mess. "We will have to think of a new model for India which imitates neither the USSR nor the US, so that while India develops, it also shows to the world the path of development," he said.

ADVANI MAY BE THE PRIME MINISTERIAL CANDIDATE BUT THE PARTY'S CAMPAIGN WON'T BE BUILT ON A PERSONALITY CULT.
